

Player to watch **SHUBMAN GILL**

By naming Gill as vice-captain for the Champions Trophy, the Indian selectors have trusted the graceful right-handed batter from Punjab. With Yashasvi Jaiswal breathing down the neck of the top order, there may have been some uncertainty about Gill's place in the playing eleven had he not been appointed as Rohit's deputy.

Now, it is up to the 25-year-old opener to prove with his performances that he deserves superstar status. He has had his ups and downs, particularly in Tests, where an average of 35.05 does not reflect his enormous talent. To be fair to Gill, he has been exceptional in the 50-over format for India, racking up 2,328 runs in 47 ODIs at an average of 58.2 and a strike rate of 101.74 (before the ODI series against England). However, to indeed follow in the footsteps of Rohit and Kohli, he will need to deliver match-winning knocks in a marquee event. The Champions Trophy could be that stage.



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PowerPlay, the middle overs, and at the death made him an indispensable asset for the team. Harshit Rana has been named as his replacement.

The onus now falls on Mohammed Shami to lead the pace attack. Shami is returning from a lengthy layoff and may need some time to find his rhythm. In the spin department, Kuldeep Yadav has also been short of game time lately, having undergone groin surgery after the Test series against New Zealand in November. The calibre of these bowlers is not in question, but the fact that they are returning from injuries is far from ideal in a major tournament.

Unlike the other teams that have matches at different venues, India will be based in Dubai for the entirety of the tournament. Once the Indian players acclimatise to the conditions,

familiarity with the pitches and ground dimensions could work to their advantage. India's decision to include four spin-bowling options in its squad suggests that the Dubai International Cricket Stadium pitches are likely to aid spin. If so, India has enough variety in this department to capitalise.

The format of the Champions Trophy is such that one bad game could push a team to the brink of a group-stage exit. The pressure to perform for India is all the more significant, as its unforgiving fans would perceive anything less than lifting the trophy as a failure. While the clash against Pakistan has high stakes riding on it, the battle with New Zealand may be just as nerve-racking, given that the Kiwis pulled off a clean sweep in a

three-match Test series in India a few months ago. As the Black Caps have demonstrated in recent years, they relish the prospect of tormenting India in conditions perceived to be in the latter's favour.

SQUAD

Rohit Sharma (c), Shubman Gill, Virat Kohli, Shreyas Iyer, KL Rahul, Hardik Pandya, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Kuldeep Yadav, Harshit Rana, Mohammed Shami, Arshdeep Singh, Varun Chakaravathy, Rishabh Pant, Ravindra Jadeja